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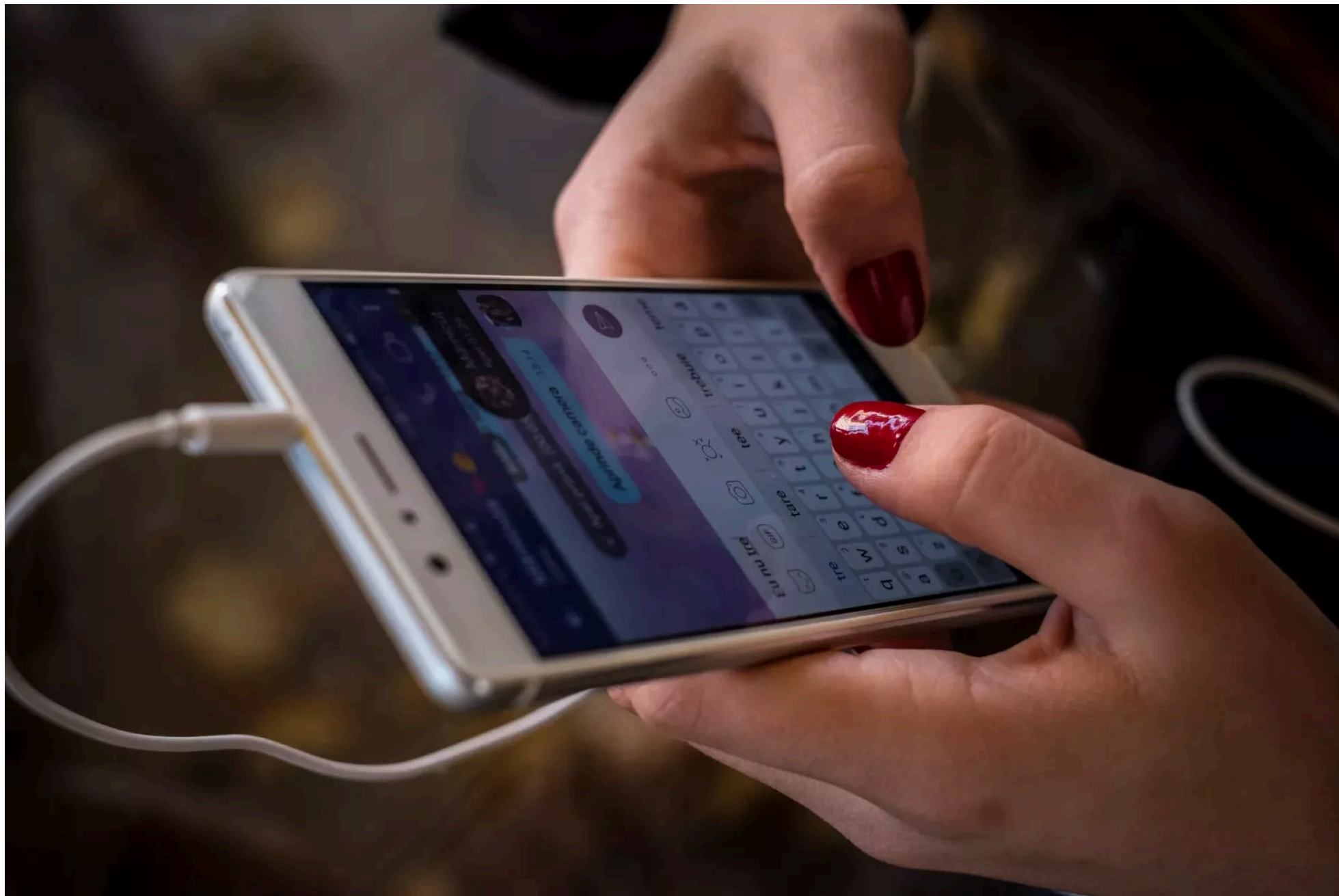
📖 Explainer

A quick guide to spotting misinformation

Tips for fact-checking, staying informed and talking it out

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Have you ever felt like you're surrounded by misinformation while reading a website or scrolling on social media? Knowing what information to trust is increasingly difficult on social media, where false claims frequently are disguised as facts. Learn how to check information online, create and consume content responsibly, and have productive discussions with people who believe misinformation.

Fake news vs disinformation vs misinformation

Fake news typically refers to news stories or headlines that are deliberately fabricated to mislead or manipulate readers. These stories often look like real news articles but are entirely made-up or twisted versions of true events, created with the intention to deceive.

Fake news is a type of disinformation: false information that is created with the intention to mislead. Disinformation includes not only fake news, but also other types of claims, such as those put out as government propaganda, or by social media accounts or brands in order to sell a product or service.

Misinformation, on the other hand, is any kind of false or inaccurate information – whether it's shared intentionally or not. People often spread misinformation because they genuinely believe it's true and don't realize they're sharing something incorrect.

How AI comes into play

Modern AI can create lifelike images, videos ("deepfakes"), audio and even write articles that seem like real news. AI-driven bots also can flood social media with the same false story over and over, making it look like everyone believes it. Keep this in mind when you see something that seems too wild to be true or feels suspicious.

How to spot misinformation and stop it from spreading

1. Foster a diverse news media ecosystem



Getting your news from multiple sources and outlets allows a wide range of information to come into your regular news content. If the same news is corroborated across multiple channels there is a higher chance that it is not misinformation.

A quick Google search can help you determine if other reliable sources are discussing the topic. If they aren't, the chances that it's fake news go way up.

2. Critically assess the credibility of sources

When in doubt, choose which information requires further investigation or follow-up questions. With information that comes from social media, tracing back the information to the original source is a great way to fight misinformation. If the information comes from a less-than-reputable source or is contrary to expert advice, be skeptical of the information presented, and make a note that the channel where you found the information may not be the best.

3. Amplify the voices of experts

Support real experts who are distinguished in their field. With any piece of content, once sourced, it's important to learn about the credentials of the author. Does this expert have an advanced degree related to the topic? Does this expert have years of experience in their field? Are they considered reputable by other people in their field? Is this peer-reviewed information from a credible academic journal?

4. Address the rumors and explain why they are incorrect

Once you have the facts in your hands, be straightforward and succinct. Avoid emphasizing misinformation when countering false claims. Explaining why misinformation is incorrect is more effective than simply labelling it as false.

How to talk to someone who believes misinformation

Understand the emotional side

A big part of why we might fall for false information is that we often see it through the lens of our emotions instead of logic. Knowing this, many creators of misinformation use strategies that play on these emotional reactions. Here are some common factors to watch out for:



1. Confirmation bias

This is when we believe information that supports what we already think. Because it matches our existing beliefs, we're more likely to share it, which only makes those beliefs stronger.

2. Need for belonging

As social beings, we want to feel part of something bigger. When we connect with people who share our opinions, this sense of belonging grows – and can strengthen certain groups and messages, whether they're good or bad, true or false.

3. Herd mentality

This happens when a number of people respond in the same way. In the case of information, if everyone is sharing a particular story, it can feel “true” just because so many people are talking about it.

4. Conspiracy theories

These tend to pop up during times of crisis or uncertainty and offer “answers” to things that are still unclear. Some key traits of conspiracy theories include:

- Being rooted in extreme suspicion, which makes people reject all other explanations.
- Belief in evil intentions behind events.
- Distrust of official stories.
- A sense of those who are "in the know" being the “brave victims” who stand up against the so-called conspirators.
- Resistance to any evidence against it, since all proof is reinterpreted as part of the conspiracy itself.

By understanding how emotions, biases, and the need to belong can lead us to trust misinformation, we can have more empathetic and effective conversations with people who believe it.

Tips for the conversation

1. Stay calm

Remember, this isn't a big argument – and it is not about winning or losing. It's about helping someone build their critical thinking skills and see things from a new angle.

2. Listen carefully

Pay attention to what the other person is saying. Practice empathy by trying to understand their worries or reasons for



believing certain information. It can help to repeat someone's argument back to them, to make sure they feel heard and to make sure you understand all of their points, before you respond with your own counterargument.

3. Ask questions

Show that you hear their points, then gently ask about facts, sources, or data. Stay curious, not confrontational.

4. Explain the nuances

Make it clear that information isn't always 100% true or 100% false. Understanding the "gray areas" is an important part of developing critical thinking.

5. Facts vs opinions

Point out that facts can be backed up with evidence, while opinions are personal points of view. Emphasize the importance of sticking to trustworthy, fact-based info.

6. Share tools for fact-checking

Show them simple ways to verify if the information is legit—like using reliable fact-checking websites or comparing multiple credible sources.

7. Suggest trusted sources

Recommend professional journalists or established researchers. They're not always perfect, but they have training, ethics, and standards for verifying info.

Keep learning

Check out United Nations Verified and wikiHow course for more tips and resources: [How to Spot and Counter Misinformation Online](#).

Related topics

